

with two established wicketkeeping options in Mahendra Singh Dhoni and Sanju Samson already in the squad.

His chances, then, may come as a specialist batter. Known for his ability to clear the ropes with ease, Kartik could strengthen CSK's middle order and grow into a finisher. "I'm not thinking too far ahead. I have just resumed my training, and the plan is to take things step by step," Kartik tells *Sportstar*.

Hailing from Bharatpur, a small town in Rajasthan best known for its bird sanctuary, Kartik is not particularly articulate and often searches for words. That hesitation, however, disappears the moment he walks out to bat.

During the 2024-25 season, Kartik captained Rajasthan's Under-19 side and stood out in the Vinoo Mankad and Cooch Behar Trophy. He scored 492 runs in the one-day competition, including a double century. A run of consistent performances earned him a spot in the senior team. Across eight First-Class matches, Kartik has scored 479 runs, while adding 445 runs in nine List A games and 334 runs in 12 T20s. The numbers might have been higher but for the injury.

Those setbacks, Kartik says, have shaped him.

"When I started playing cricket, my father took me to an academy where coaches felt I was too small and did not have the talent. That was an early setback. But my father did not give up," he says.

His father, Manoj, a die-hard cricket fan, and his mother, Radha, did everything they could to ensure their son pursued the sport. In a small town like Bharatpur, where resources were limited, the path was never easy. With support from Bharatpur District Cricket Association secretary Shatrudhan Tiwary, Manoj ensured Kartik received the right exposure.

"My father did everything that he could to make me a cricketer. It was very challenging for him, since resources were limited and we were not financially strong. But that was never a deterrent for him," Kartik says.

**Power-hitting:** Kartik Sharma was the joint-highest six-hitter in the first phase of the 2025-26 Ranji season and the highest six-hitter in the previous Vijay Hazare Trophy.

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